



A face off between  
Mandriva Linux 2009.1  
Spring and the release  
candidate of Windows 7.



# Fight Club

The war has begun. Quite literally. The final release of Windows 7, the latest (and greatest?) version of Windows is just months away. We laid our hands on the RC (release candidate) available for free on Microsoft's website, and took it for a spin against Mandriva 2009.1 Spring. Who won? The results are most surprising!

## The hardware platform

We tested out both the operating systems on a pretty standard multimedia PC. The specs of the system are given below:

- Processor: Intel Core2 Duo E7200 @ 2.53GHz, 45nm Core Fabrication, without Intel VT.
- Memory: 2GB Transcend DDR2-800MHz JetRam
- Chipset: nVidia nForce 630i MCP
- Graphics (Onboard): nVidia nForce 630i/GeForce 7100
- Graphics (PCIe): nVidia GeForce 9400GT
- Networking: nVidia nForce MCP73 Networking Controller (Realtek RTL8139 Chip)
- Sound: Realtek AC'97 8 Channel High Definition On-board Audio (ALSA: Intel\_HDA)
- Hard Disk (Primary): Seagate Barracuda 7200.11 320GB SATA2

- Hard Disk (Secondary, Hosting our OSs): Western Digital Caviar 160GB 7200RPM SATA2
- Display: Samsung SyncMaster 510N (15" or 38.1cm, LCD-TFT, VGA Connection)
- Mouse and Keyboard: Microsoft Digital Media K/B and Microsoft Wireless Optical Mouse

Now that you know the specs of our system, it's time to move on!

## The packages compared

Both Windows 7 RC and Mandriva 2009.1 Spring (Free) come on single-layer DVDs. Windows 7 is a smaller download at 2.35 GB, whereas Mandriva weighs in at 4.34 GB, or 1.99 GB more. Both are ISO images, and have to be burned onto a disk.

## Installation: Head-on

We started out by creating two empty unformatted partitions of 25 GB each on the shiny new caviar. Then, after starting the countdown timer, we started the computer with the Windows 7 RC DVD in the drive. A little while later, a plain text message greeted us: "Press any key to boot from CD or DVD" with a growing number of dots after it (it's supposed to stay five seconds, after which it